

Security Crisis or Qualitative Change? Evidence from Violent Property Crimes in Chile, 2013–2025

Summary and Contribution:

The authors use administrative crime records from the Chilean Police to analyze total and compositional changes in robbery and property crimes from 2013-2025. They find that while the total volume of these crime types was in decline, this masked a compositional change as the ratio of violent robberies to property crime increased – driven primarily by a decline of non-violent robberies. I appreciate the emphasis on crime composition as an important target of inquiry – in particular their trichotomous classification that allows for the unpacking of bifurcated effects, the authors’ sharp eye towards policy implications that follow from the documented compositional shift, as well as the empirically rigorous identification of temporal breakpoints and flexible and appropriate modeling strategy for the data. Further, their falsification and robustness checks included lends credence to the validity of the results. I believe this paper can be an informative contribution to criminological understanding of compositional crime shifts – and the complex ways these shifts can take place - but believe the paper would stand a chance at making a more substantial and wide-ranging contribution with the following revisions.

Major Comments:

- The authors make a valuable contribution by assessing the compositional changes in property crime. However, while the authors do state that “the perception of a ‘crisis’ therefore has a real empirical basis (p. 2)”, I’m left wanting a discussion of the empirical link between “objective” crime trends and public perception. Research indicates that crime perceptions/fear of crime, punitive policy support, and other crime related attitudes are responsive to a host of other social factors more consistent with a constructivist model (i.e., media coverage, political rhetoric, ideology, etc.) as opposed to an objectivist model where crime perceptions closely follow crime trends (e.g., Beckett 1997; Shi et al. 2020). While I acknowledge that this paper’s goal is *not* to empirically make this tie in Chile, I think that a discussion of this research would make the mechanisms empirically driving crime perceptions explicit and give a more robust account for the development of the Chilean security crisis the authors discuss.
 - o Relatedly, a discussion of empirical work linking public perception of crime and policy attitudes and responses (e.g., Enns 2014, Enns 2016, Duxbury 2021) would help shore up these perceptual claims in the front end.
 - o In the Chilean context there is relatively less scholarship on recent crime perceptions, but Marambio & Navia (2026) analyze a survey data and find some similar factors are implicated in crime perceptions in Chile, although claims about perceptual change are not possible in their cross-sectional design.
- On p. 8 the authors cite the 2019 Chilean protests, but do not foreground these events in the front end. This is one of the key structural breakpoints empirically identified in the analysis, yet little context, previous scholarship, or theoretical expectations are discussed in relation to this moment. Some added context to these events, their precipitation, and their social effects would be useful to readers unfamiliar with the Chilean social context.

- In my read, the main model is effectively an interrupted time series (ITS) design with multiple interruptions and restricted cubic splines and month dummies to adjust for seasonality. I think this is an appropriate design given the research questions at hand, but have a few concerns related to discussion of causal inference and testing regarding the model:
 - There is no discussion as to the causal inference assumptions inherent in this design. ITS designs compare the levels of outcomes after treatment to the outcome level in the pre-intervention period, and discussion around the assumed counterfactual (i.e., the post-treatment robbery level without the pandemic intervention) is absent. It would be illustrative to make this explicit for readers.
 - The design exclusively uses within-unit over time variation, so time-stable confounders are uncorrelated with the intervention, a great benefit to the analysis at hand. However, the design is susceptible to time-varying unobserved heterogeneity, and this should be stated in the analytical strategy and limitations sections – particularly as few other time-varying controls are included in the main model. To be fair¹, I do not have particular forces in mind that may confound the identified effects (as I am not an expert in the Chilean context), but the possibility here should be acknowledged.
 - ITS designs are also susceptible to autocorrelation. Partial autocorrelation functions (PACF) could be estimated to determine if there is significant autocorrelation in the series, and autoregressive terms could be added to the model to account for this dependency if it exists.
 - ITS designs are also susceptible to bias if the series is nonstationary. I commend the authors for including splines to flexibly capture deterministic trends, these terms do not capture temporal fluctuations that are stochastic. To avoid risks of “spurious regression” (Enders 2015), the authors should include some test of stationarity to assess residual stationarity (i.e., ADF or KPSS tests).
- I find the regional heterogeneity results compelling. However, discussion around why certain areas were responsive to the pandemic and others were not remain unexplored in the discussion on p.17. What is it about the areas that did not have structural breaks to the pandemic? What social factors may have provided a buffer to absolute and/or compositional shifts? Perhaps further analysis that includes regional social indicators could provide paths to investigate this question.

Minor Comments:

- In their robust discussion of theoretical expectations, the authors state how “heightened absolute inequality (p.5)” can alter the rational choice calculus under deterrence theory. This is theoretically coherent, but inequality can impact crime composition through other mechanisms as well – such as collective efficacy, strain, etc. – that may give insight to the compositional shifts. This leaves me wondering in a social context of elevated inequality – how might the pandemic shift these social causes of crime as well? When mobility falls and social network closure heightens – as is the case in the pandemic – perhaps elevated strain kept violent robberies from decreasing at similar rates as non-violent robberies? Perhaps social closure

¹ In other words, not trying to be difficult here!

differentially weakened informal social controls as it pertains to violence as opposed to nonviolent robbery? Perhaps these mechanisms should be thought through as well.

- I appreciate the migratory correction in the population denominators. As it is currently written, the correction “adds the cumulative stock of temporary and permanent residence permits issued by the National Migration Service (p. 7)”. However, even if Chile is experiencing net immigration growth, how is emigration accounted for? It appears that only inflows are adjusted for. If outflows are not adjusted for, this may not reflect a true lower bound as claimed on p.9. This is a small detail unlikely to shift the substantive results of the analysis but should be made explicit.
- The use of Wild Cluster Bootstrapping for inference is commendable. However, in my understanding this is an inferential technique that is not tied to the model/estimator itself. In other words, this may not be a logical justification for the poisson-QMLE as stated, but rather an applicable extension to many different models to perform valid inference with low-cluster data.
- One addition that would substantially increase the contribution of this paper is having some measure of the mediating mechanisms (i.e., pandemic → X → crime) that could help substantiate the theoretical mechanisms proposed. However, I acknowledge that data that can measure mobility, protest activity, institutional trust, etc. are notoriously hard to come by. This paper is already doing enough to make a contribution (particularly with its unique Chilean context), so I leave it to the editors to determine whether an extension like this is warranted. At minimum, this could be added to the “future research agenda” section to perhaps spur further work to disentangle these mechanisms.
- As stated above, I find the regional heterogeneity in the effect compelling and well explored. However, the structural breaks identified in Table 5 and Figure 5 do not neatly correspond to the breaks modeled in the main specification. This follows more of a discovery approach as opposed to a confirmatory approach in the main model. While I like the specificity with which these breakpoints are estimated, some discussion would be helpful to the flow of the manuscript to clearly state that these are a separate approach to the main specification.
- While the aforementioned detailed breaks are interesting, I’m left wanting a bit as to the uprising and pandemic effect regional heterogeneity. There is a bit of this with the macro-zone X spline interaction model, and I might recommend moving these results into the main body of the paper in section 4.3 as a precursor to the more detailed break analysis alongside similar interaction effects for the interventions in the main specification (these are not included in the manuscript as of now I do not believe). An alternative and intuitive way to present these results would be to map the estimated breaks and splines (main effect + interaction term) spatially in a faceted figure. This would retain the spatial picture, and I think provide an intuitive way for readers unfamiliar with Chile to grasp the spatial heterogeneity at play.